

SECTION 01 • A FIELD GUIDE FOR THE EARLY WEEKS

The first 30 days.

A practical checklist for the early weeks after separation. Print it. Tick it. Come back to it.

THIS CHECKLIST HELPS YOU

Reduce overwhelm

Organise immediate priorities

Protect important information

Create practical structure

Avoid small problems becoming larger

Keep the wheels on, this week

PAGE 01 • STABILISE

Stabilise the loud things first.

When everything feels emotionally loud, practical clarity matters. Focus on safety, money, communication, immediate routines, and protecting important information.

- Safety
- Communication
- Important information
- Money
- Immediate routines
- Tick what matters now

01 Safety & housing

● PRIORITY — IMMEDIATE

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Confirm where everyone is sleeping this week. | ☐ Make sure you have access to keys, transport, essential items. |
| ☐ Reset passwords on email, banking, iCloud or Google, and any shared accounts — today. | ☐ Check shared device access: Find My, location sharing, family screen time. Disable what needs disabling. |
| ☐ Change garage codes and any shared home security PINs. | ☐ Photograph shared assets and major household items now, before anything moves. |
| ☐ Collect passports, birth certificates, essential documents. Somewhere only you can access. | ☐ Create a list of major shared belongings. |
| ☐ Check access to medications and medical information — yours and the kids'. | ☐ Confirm emergency contacts for the children at school and childcare. |
| ☐ Prepare a temporary overnight bag for the kids with essentials. | ☐ Duplicate essentials across both homes: chargers, toiletries, school uniforms. |
| ☐ Store copies of important files in a private folder — physical or cloud, your access only. | |

02 Banking & money

● PRIORITY — HIGH

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Open a personal bank account in your name only, if you don't already have one. | ☐ Move enough to cover two weeks of ordinary expenses into that account. |
| ☐ Reset passwords on all personal financial accounts. | ☐ Screenshot all joint account balances and recent transactions — today, before anything changes. |
| ☐ Download recent bank statements (last 3–6 months). | ☐ Download mortgage or loan statements. |
| ☐ List all recurring subscriptions and direct debits. | ☐ Note which credit cards are in joint names. |
| ☐ Check credit card access and current limits. | ☐ Record current savings balances. |
| ☐ Record all debts and repayment amounts. | ☐ Save copies of payslips and tax returns. |
| ☐ Check superannuation balances — and update your beneficiary. | ☐ Note upcoming bill due dates in the next 30 days. |
| ☐ Set a spending freeze on non-essentials while the picture is still unclear. | ☐ Sketch a rough budget — income, fixed costs, the gap. Not perfect. Just real. |
| ☐ List every account or asset you don't yet have full clarity on. Come back later. | |

Children need predictability, not perfection.

Children benefit from predictability, even when the adults are still figuring things out. The goal is not perfection. The goal is reducing unnecessary chaos.

Legal and admin work happens alongside it — quietly, in a folder, on a list.

03 Kids & school

● PRIORITY — HIGH

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Create a shared weekly kids calendar — who has the kids each night for the next four weeks. | ☐ Write down the current routine in full — pickups, bedtimes, meals, activities — before it becomes disputed. |
| ☐ Confirm school drop-off and pick-up arrangements for this week. | ☐ Check extracurricular schedules and confirm transport for each. |
| ☐ Duplicate school essentials across both homes: uniforms, bags, stationery. | ☐ List important school contacts: class teacher, front office, year coordinator. |
| ☐ Confirm current medical appointments and medications for each child. | ☐ Duplicate comfort items for younger children where possible. |
| ☐ Check sports schedules and sort transport for the next two weeks. | ☐ Note upcoming birthdays, school events, and term dates. |
| ☐ List three people who can cover childcare at short notice. | |

04 Legal & admin

● PRIORITY — MEDIUM

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|--|--|
| ☐ Redirect important mail to your new address or a private PO box. | ☐ Create a document folder — one per category: Financial, Kids, Legal, Property. |
| ☐ Save copies of insurance policies — home, car, health, life. | ☐ Save copies of the last two years of tax returns. |
| ☐ Save copies of property documents, title, and mortgage. | ☐ Check Medicare details — update address and contact information. |
| ☐ Check private health insurance — confirm cover, update contact details. | ☐ Update emergency contacts across all accounts. |
| ☐ List all shared utilities and accounts — whose name, who's paying. | ☐ Start a dated log of significant conversations with your ex — written immediately after a call. |
| ☐ Start a simple timeline: separation date, key agreements, significant events. | ☐ Prepare two or three questions for your first legal or mediation appointment. |

PAGE 03 • STEADY THE GROUND

Small stabilising actions beat dramatic reinvention.

The early weeks after separation create decision fatigue, mental fog, and operational backlog. Sleep, eat, write things down. The floor first, then the rest.

05 Emotional support

● PRIORITY — IMPORTANT

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Tell one trusted person what is happening — someone who will hold it, not amplify it. | ☐ Identify who in your life feels calming rather than escalating. Stay close to them. |
| ☐ See your GP this week. Tell them what's happening. Ask about a Mental Health Treatment Plan. | ☐ Book professional support if needed — get the pathway open before you're in crisis. |
| ☐ Reduce exposure to conflict-heavy conversations where possible. | ☐ Make no major life decisions this month if it can be avoided — housing, career, relationships. |
| ☐ Be deliberate about alcohol. Separation is one of the highest-risk periods for dependency to form. | ☐ Keep basic sleep and eating routines running. These are the floor. |
| ☐ Spend time outside each day if you can. | ☐ Write things down rather than carrying everything mentally. That's what Atlas is for. |

06 Immediate practicals

● PRIORITY — ONGOING

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Set up a simple weekly meal structure — nothing elaborate, just predictable. | ☐ Restock basic groceries across both homes. |
| ☐ Set reminders for all upcoming appointments and bill due dates. | ☐ Organise a simple laundry and school-prep rhythm for the week ahead. |
| ☐ Write down the next seven days — kids, money, admin, appointments. One place, one list. | |

"The first month after separation is mostly an organisation problem dressed up as an emotional one."

ATLAS — FIELD NOTE

PAGE 04 • THE NEXT STEP

Enough stability for clearer decisions later.

You do not need to rebuild your entire life this month. Small systems reduce stress. Simple routines restore capacity. Clarity returns gradually.

07 Weekly check-in

● RIGHT NOW — WHAT NEEDS ATTENTION FIRST

Money

NOTE

NOTE

Kids

NOTE

NOTE

Admin

NOTE

NOTE

Housing

NOTE

NOTE

Support

NOTE

NOTE

One thing this week

DO

DO

CLOSING NOTE

That is not a small thing. But it is a solvable one.

The first month is mostly an organisation problem. Focus on stability, clarity, consistency, and small practical wins. Atlas exists to help you move through this one week at a time.

STABILITY

CLARITY

CONSISTENCY

SMALL WINS

IMMEDIATE STABILISATION • TOOL 02

Emergency budget.

Get the numbers quiet enough to think. A practical reset for the first phase after separation.

THIS WORKSHEET HELPS YOU

Understand your real monthly position

Reduce unnecessary spending pressure

Identify immediate financial risks

Stabilise essential systems first

See a bare-minimum survival number

Plan a small, realistic buffer

What does survival actually cost?

Separation creates financial fog. The goal here is not perfection or optimisation. The goal is one clean look at the real monthly position. Approximate is fine.

01 Monthly income

INCOME SOURCE	AMOUNT
Salary / wages	\$
Child support	\$
Centrelink / benefits	\$
Freelance / side income	\$
Rental income	\$
Other	\$
MONTHLY INCOME	
\$	

02 Essential expenses

ESSENTIAL EXPENSE	MONTHLY
Rent / mortgage	\$
Utilities	\$
Groceries	\$
Fuel / transport	\$
Insurance	\$
Phone / internet	\$
Child expenses	\$
School costs	\$
Medical & medication	\$
Debt repayments	\$
Other essentials	\$
ESSENTIAL MONTHLY COST	
\$	

Pressure off, not punishment on.

Some expenses are survival. Some are comfort. Some are future problems disguised as current necessities.

Pause is temporary. Sort each row, then move on.

03 Optional & pausable expenses

● SORT EACH ROW

EXPENSE	KEEP	PAUSE	REDUCE
Streaming services	☐	☐	☐
Gym & memberships	☐	☐	☐
Dining out	☐	☐	☐
App & software subscriptions	☐	☐	☐
Shopping & clothing	☐	☐	☐
Alcohol	☐	☐	☐
Kids extras & activities	☐	☐	☐
Holidays & travel	☐	☐	☐
Entertainment	☐	☐	☐
Other	☐	☐	☐

04 Immediate financial risks

● TICK WHAT'S LIVE

☐ Upcoming large bills in the next 30 days.	☐ Shared debt with unclear obligation.
☐ Housing instability or short notice period.	☐ Credit card balance creeping up.
☐ Tax uncertainty — return, BAS, or debt.	☐ Legal costs without a clear ceiling.
☐ Reduced or uncertain income.	☐ Childcare costs likely to change.
☐ Vehicle costs — rego, service, repairs.	☐ Insurance gap — health, car, contents.

PAGE 03 • SURVIVAL NUMBER

If things got tight — what do we need?

This number matters psychologically. It creates realism, contingency, calmer decisions. You are not living here — you are knowing where the floor is.

05 Survival budget — essentials only

● FLOOR, NOT LIFESTYLE

CATEGORY	MINIMUM MONTHLY COST
Housing	\$
Food	\$
Utilities	\$
Transport	\$
Children	\$
Insurance	\$
Medical	\$
Debt minimums	\$
Phone / internet	\$
Other essentials	\$

BARE MINIMUM MONTHLY
SURVIVAL NUMBER

\$

If income dropped suddenly — what would matter most, and what would stay protected first?

PAGE 04 • STABILISE

Sustainability, not optimisation.

Once the immediate pressure reduces, the goal becomes stability. Not survival. Not optimisation. Just a month that doesn't quietly take more than it gives.

06 Stabilised budget

● MONTHLY TARGET

CATEGORY	MONTHLY COST
Essentials (from page 01)	\$
Kids activities	\$
Savings buffer	\$
Social & connection	\$
Health & fitness	\$
Household maintenance	\$
Clothing	\$
Small enjoyment budget	\$

STABILISED MONTHLY
NUMBER

\$

07 Emergency buffer target

● BREATHING ROOM

BUFFER LEVEL	TARGET AMOUNT
One week of essentials	\$
One month of essentials	\$
Three months of essentials	\$

What is the first realistic buffer target?

PAGE 05 • REBUILD

Stable, deliberate, less reactive.

Rebuild is not about becoming rich. It's the slow return of future planning, alongside the biggest single source of separation stress: housing.

08 Rebuild budget

● FUTURE MONTHLY TARGET

CATEGORY	FUTURE MONTHLY TARGET
Housing stability	\$
Savings	\$
Debt reduction	\$
Kids future costs	\$
Career growth	\$
Health & wellbeing	\$
Social life & experiences	\$
Long-term goals	\$

09 Housing pressure calculator

● LARGEST SINGLE SOURCE OF STRESS

MONTHLY HOUSING COSTS	MONTHLY INCOME	PERCENTAGE OF INCOME
\$	\$	%

UNDER 30%

Manageable

Generally workable. Keep the buffer growing and revisit annually.

30-45%

Active

Requires active budgeting. Watch the optional column closely.

OVER 45%

Pressure

Ongoing financial pressure, reduced flexibility. Consider structural change.

PAGE 06 • SUMMARY

See it clearly enough to stop catastrophising.

Carry these four numbers forward. Re-do them in a month. Most of the panic comes from not knowing — and now you know.

10 Financial snapshot — right now

● CARRY THESE FOUR NUMBERS

BARE MINIMUM SURVIVAL

\$

STABILISED MONTHLY TARGET

\$

BIGGEST FINANCIAL PRESSURE

NEXT PRACTICAL FINANCIAL STEP

CLOSING NOTE

Visible numbers reduce fear.

Financial clarity does not solve everything. But uncertainty consumes enormous emotional energy. Small systems reduce panic. Progress often starts with seeing the situation clearly enough to stop catastrophising it.

CLARITY

VISIBILITY

BREATHING ROOM

STEADIER DECISIONS

IMMEDIATE STABILISATION • TOOL 03

Financial snapshot.

Your situation is probably clearer than your nervous system thinks it is.

A CLARITY TOOL, IN 20 MINUTES

Cash on hand, today

Monthly income, all sources

Debts in one place

Property & assets noted

Ongoing costs, approximate

Upcoming pressure, named

PAGE 01 • CASH, INCOME, DEBTS

Approximate clarity beats mental chaos.

Not a legal disclosure. Not a tax worksheet. Just one clean look at where things stand, fast enough that the nervous system can finally settle.

01 Cash & accounts

● AVAILABLE TODAY

ACCOUNT / CASH SOURCE	APPROXIMATE AMOUNT
Everyday account	\$
Savings	\$
Offset account	\$
Cash on hand	\$
Shared accounts	\$
Other	\$

TOTAL AVAILABLE CASH \$

02 Debts & liabilities

● ALL KNOWN BALANCES

DEBT	APPROXIMATE BALANCE
Mortgage	\$
Credit cards	\$
Personal loans	\$
Car loans	\$
Tax debt	\$
Buy now, pay later	\$
Other	\$

TOTAL DEBT \$

03 Property & assets

ASSET	EST. VALUE
Home property	\$
Investment property	\$
Vehicles	\$
Shares / investments	\$
Superannuation	\$
Other	\$

ESTIMATED ASSET
TOTAL \$

04 Monthly income

INCOME SOURCE	MONTHLY
Salary / wages	\$
Child support	\$
Government support	\$
Freelance / other	\$
Rental income	\$
Other	\$

ESTIMATED
MONTHLY INCOME \$

05 Upcoming financial pressure

● NAME WHAT'S COMING

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Upcoming legal costs. | ☐ Housing uncertainty. |
| ☐ School fees. | ☐ Vehicle expenses — rego, service, repairs. |
| ☐ Tax obligations. | ☐ Reduced income risk. |
| ☐ Debt repayment pressure. | ☐ Medical costs. |
| ☐ Shared asset uncertainty. | ☐ Childcare cost changes. |

Right now — what feels financially unclear, and what's the next practical thing to organise?